

ARLnow

Local is everything

Get Peace of Mind

- Estate Planning
- Probate and Estate Administration
- Civil Litigation
- Business Law



[News](#)

Arlington leader took on Virginia's mid-century political machine and paid the price

By **Scott McCaffrey**

Published April 3, 2026 at 2:00PM

NEW DEAL DIES, GOP HOLDS CONGRESS

Democrats Win All In Virginia Election

Over 200,000 Went To Polls

By Associated Press

The Commonwealth's Democratic party met an unprecedented Republican challenge in yesterday's general election and emerged victorious with its voters' vote intact.

A heavy vote swept all of the Democratic nominees, headed by Senator Harry Byrd, incumbent, and Senate Candidate A. Willis Robertson, into office by a big majority.

Complete tabulations of the Virginia vote were still not available at this writing, but there are enough key precincts to make the outcome certain and to indicate that upwards of 210,000 Old Democrats went to the polls in one of the State's biggest off-year elections in history.

Gets Third Term

Virginia has elected Senator Harry Flood Byrd, the Winchester apple grower and veteran statesman, to his third full term in the Senate. Voters also elected A. Willis Robertson, the Lexington statesman and a veteran of the House of Representatives, to the short Senate term.

Results so far in 1946 out of 372 precincts give Byrd 154,842 votes to 75,323 for Republican Lester S. Parsons.

For the short term, Robertson has 128,385 to 66,901 for Republican Robert Woods.

Democrats also swept the Congressional races, including 13 seats, where the Republicans, 31

Dugan Reiterates Platform; Rivals Exchange Compliments

Postelection statements by Daniel A. Dugan, newly-elected member of the County Board, indicate that Arlington is due for rapid acceleration in housing, school and veteran services.

First reforms planned by Dugan center on:

(1) Establishing a committee to study the housing problem of Arlington and its environs in Arlington; (2) setting up a veterans' information center, staffed with volunteer workers from the ranks of professional and business men;

(3) Counting on accredited wage high school, which Dugan says will be effected in the proposed \$1250, 000 bond issue for school improvements.

Robertson are pledged.

Reiterating his intention to carry out the reforms set forth in his campaign platform, Dugan, last night said he considered the election results "a victory for non-partisan bond elections in Arlington."

He praised his defeated opponent, Edmund D. Campbell, as "a thorough gentleman" and complimented him on the way he conducted his campaign.

"I consider Mr. Campbell the best member on the County Board," he concluded.

Dugan expressed "gratitude and appreciation" to the voters, and said he would "do everything within my power to live up to the confidence of those who elected me."

Dugan's term on the County Board begins January 1, 1947, and runs for four years. Robertson's position is 41,200 per cent.

Campbell Statement

Defeated in his quest of a third term on the County Board, Edmund D. Campbell today refused to confirm rumors he would break with the Democratic Party.

Campbell had no comment on whether or not he would run for



DANIEL A. DUGAN
The Winner



EDMUND D. CAMPBELL
Made Long Term

Eighth District Democrats Poll 64 Percent

Eighth Congressional District

Campbell Loses Race In County Upheaval

Dugan Carries Seven Precincts

By JOHN D. DICKERSON

Sweeping seven of Arlington's eleven voting precincts, defeated Daniel A. Dugan last night scored the greatest political upset in recent county history, defeating Democrat Edmund D. Campbell, incumbent chairman of the County Board, by a margin of 900 votes.

An off-guarded vote, which proved costly by the fourth, when 30,000 voters attended to the polls yesterday to ballot on two U. S. Senators, a Representative from the Eighth Congressional District, one member of the County Board and a referendum on tax Federal property in the State of Virginia. Counting of many votes and a brief wind, the record turnout attended seven political leaders long before the polls closed at 5 p.m.

Campbell conceded defeat shortly after 11 o'clock last night when Dugan continued to compile majorities across the county. Last night's tabulations gave Dugan 3,700 ballots to Campbell's 4,602.

The independent candidate carried Arlington, Ballston, Clarks, Chantilly, No. 2 Glen Carbon, Lynn Park and Rosslyn precincts, while the Board Chairman was swept in Falls Church, Chantilly, Virginia Highlands and Chantilly No. 2.

Dugan pulled more votes than any candidate in the Senatorial or Congressional races, beating his closest competitors, A. Willis Robertson, Democratic nominee for the unexpired term of the late Senator Carter Glass, Jr. and incumbent Senator Harry F. Byrd.



Lyman L. King Promoted To Lieutenant

Three promotions and one transfer for the Arlington Police Department were announced yesterday by Chief Harry L. Woodward.

Age Lyman L. King was promoted to Lieutenant, and Privates E. S. "Boss" Cole and F. W. Finkler were promoted to Sergeants. Lieutenant John F. Sanders was transferred to the Detective Bureau as a plainclothesman of his own request.

King has been with the force for 11 years. Privates Cole and Finkler for 5. Sanders, a veteran of nine years in the department, held the rank of Lieutenant for a year and was formerly a member of the Detective Bureau.

Appointments became effective the first of this month.



Charley McCarthy Gets Vote In Rosslyn

Last night's election was not without its humorous side.

In Rosslyn precinct, someone, obsessed with the idea that neither Ed Campbell nor Dan Dugan were fit for the County Board, scribbled the name "Charlie McCarthy" on the ballot and placed an "X" there by.

No one could discern to which political faction Charlie owed allegiance, as his nomination failed to bring an election vote.

Charlie's random political career did not end there. He was elected with one vote.



Senator Byrd Leads Ticket In Fairfax

Democratic candidates carried the polls in seven of the Fairfax County election results in the U. S. Senate and Congressional races.

The margins for the three races indicate almost three times by comfortable margins.

Senator Harry Flood Byrd led the ticket, carrying out his victory with a 210,000 margin over the total vote recorded for his two opponents. The State Democratic leader polled a total vote of 7,800, giving the county's 25 precincts more than that, 84 votes.

A Conservative tide has rolled across the nation. And as a result, for the next two years, a Democratic President and a Republican Congress will shape the country's foreign and domestic policies. Democratic campaigners told voters that such a division would paralyze the national Government.

May Robert Tamm, however, on the domestic scene.

Landslide Gives GOP Complete Majority

Foreign Policy Change Unlikely; Alteration Seen For Home Front

By United Press

A landslide last night swept the Republican party into control of both Houses of Congress for the first time in 14 years.

The GOP definitely has won the 41 seats needed for a majority in the Senate, and that lead may be increased when all the returns are in. As for the House of Representatives, the Republicans are assured of a far working majority. With 215 seats required for a majority, they have 200 definite and are leading in more for 25 more. This makes a total of 244 they either have won or are leading.

As this moment in the count of votes, the prospects are that the GOP will control the House of Representatives by a minimum of 51 seats.

45-Year Career

And this gives a vivid picture of the tremendous tidal wave that has swept over the Democrats. For in the last Congress, the Democrats controlled the House by less than that, 44 votes.

A Conservative tide has rolled across the nation. And as a result, for the next two years, a Democratic President and a Republican Congress will shape the country's foreign and domestic policies. Democratic campaigners told voters that such a division would paralyze the national Government.

May Robert Tamm, however, on the domestic scene.

News coverage day after 1946 election, with County Board results in center column (Arlington Daily via Virginia Chronicle)

This reporting was supported by the [ARLnow Press Club](#). Join to support in-depth local journalism — and get an exclusive early morning email with a preview of that day's planned news coverage.

By the [time of his death](#) in late 1995 at age 96, Edmund Campbell [had been lionized](#) as a civic leader and statesman whose legacy extended well beyond Arlington into state and national affairs.

The Washington Post ran a lengthy editorial on Dec. 17 of that year, describing Campbell as "a pioneer civic leader and force for good local government."

The editorial praised his two terms on the County Board (1939-46) as a time when Arlington implemented its first master zoning plan, established an elected school board

and grappled with issues not only of World War II but of postwar planning.

It noted his [years as an attorney](#), often taking civil-rights cases that would, over time, help bring an end to state-mandated segregation policies. And it waxed rhapsodic about his marriage to Elizabeth Campbell, a [potent force in her own right](#) who served on the School Board and founded what became the public-television giant WETA.

Much less coverage had resulted five and a half years earlier, when Daniel Dugan had died at age 74 of congestive heart failure at Northern Virginia Doctors Hospital on Aug. 8, 1990.

A [few modest obituaries](#) memorialized the life of Dugan, who was living in Reston at the time of his death, but there were no grand retrospectives like those lionizing Campbell upon his death.

And yet, in 1946, Dugan had pulled off one of the greatest political upsets in County Board history. His victim? Edmund Campbell.



Former County Board member Daniel Dugan donates several copies of his book, “And Night Came Down,” to Arlington library director Jane Nida in early 1960s (photo by Bill Little via Charlie Clark Center for Local History)

Running as an independent, Dugan trounced Campbell, who was serving as Board chair and had the full backing of not just the Arlington County Democratic Committee, but the powerful state political machine of Sen. Harry Byrd.

Campbell, a champion for liberal causes, backed by the Byrd Machine? It simply goes to show that Virginia politics in 1946 made for some strange bedfellows.

The 1946 County Board campaign has been largely lost to history, but was brought back to life during a [recent presentation at the Arlington Historical Society](#) by William Fogarty. Fogarty is a retired attorney who pens the “Our Man in Arlington” column in the Falls Church News-Press and researches and writes about county history.

His presentation focused primarily on the 1946 election, describing the Arlington County Board results as the first crack in the Byrd Machine across the commonwealth.

A look deeper into Dugan’s victory and his subsequent term and a half in elected office reveals a wild time in local governance, with many attempting to remove partisanship from local elected office and others fighting to retain it.

By the early 1950s, Dugan had cobbled together a 3-2 majority of independents on the County Board, and looked well on his way to becoming a power broker in a post-partisan political world in the county.

But the Byrd Machine struck back. Using a state law from 1788 and its control of Virginia’s judiciary, conservative Democratic forces managed to remove all three independents from office.

Campbell — who was representing the three independents in their legal battle to retain office — would decades later refer to it as a “[judicial coup d’etat](#).”

Despite promises to run for office again, Dugan largely faded from the public scene. The county government’s archives contain exactly one photograph of him, presenting a book

he had written to the county's library director in the early 1960s.

He participated in no known oral-history projects before his death, which might have served to flesh out the historical record.

Drawing from media coverage of the time, ARLnow has pieced together elements of the 1946 election and subsequent events in Dugan's political life.

A campaign launched from out of nowhere

Having served two four-year terms without drawing much flak from the public, it seemed likely that Edmund Campbell would cruise to victory in his quest for reelection in 1946.

He had been chosen by his four colleagues to chair the body that year, giving him a prominent voice even before the campaign began. Backing by the local and state Democratic establishments only helped Campbell's chances, or so it would have seemed at the time.

So, little was expected when Daniel Dugan, then 30 years old, announced plans to take on the 47-year-old Campbell as an independent. It was not deemed worthy of banner-headline coverage by any of Arlington's newspapers — the Sun, Arlington Daily and Chronicle among them.

Coverage was also spotty among the major metro dailies, The Washington Post and Evening Star.

The same edition of the Sun that reported on Dugan's campaign launch noted, in a separate article, that he had just been installed as president of the John Lyon Post of Veterans of Foreign Wars.

The connection to veterans would become an important theme of Dugan's insurgent campaign in a race that included not just Campbell, but independent H.H. Howe, as well.

The issues of 1946

As 1946 dawned, Arlington — like the nation — was making a welcomed, but complex, transition back to peacetime.

The county, which had ballooned during wartime to 115,000 residents that year, would face issues over housing, zoning, education and the political power of the County Board.

There was also the question of whether Arlington should be incorporated as a city, something sought by the Byrd forces and first introduced into the General Assembly in 1942.

In February 1946, Campbell and Charles Fenwick (then a state delegate) announced their support for incorporation as a city. Leading the opposition was the county's Republican treasurer, John Locke Green. His name will crop up later in the Dugan saga.

In March 1946, the General Assembly considered the legislation, but Fogarty said it went nowhere.

"I don't even see where [supporters] tried to have a petition," he said in the historical society presentation. "They needed to have 1,000 signatures to get the legislation on for a referendum, and nothing happened."

Supporters of a proposal to eliminate staggered terms of County Board members did launch a petition drive on that issue, aided by support from the Arlington County Civic Federation.

But it was rejected by the court both for having missed the deadline and having only 167 signatures, not the required 200, Fogarty said.

There were also battles over appointments to the School Trustee Electoral Board, the body that then appointed the School Board.

To lobby for better educational services and more responsive government in general, the Citizens Committee for School Improvements was founded. That body demanded that the Rev. Paul Hunter of Rock Spring Congregational Church be appointed to the School Board.

When Hunter, the father of future County Board member James Hunter III, was rejected by Circuit Court Judge Walter McCarthy, the group staged a sit-down strike, but still did not get its way.

With that much going on in the community, it would have been wise for Campbell to have heeded the political dictum of a future county commonwealth's attorney, who often said an incumbent needs to run "either unopposed, or scared."



Edmund and Elizabeth Campbell (via Arlington Public Library)

Playgrounds become campaign flashpoint

Looking toward the postwar period and anticipating the Baby Boom to come, Arlington voters in 1943 had approved a bond referendum to acquire land for playgrounds and build them throughout the county.

Three years later, the Dugan campaign used a lack of action as a campaign issue, appealing to parents of young children and those who expected to soon be in that demographic.

The Sept. 13 Northern Virginia Sun noted Dugan's criticism of the incumbent County Board and County Manager Frank Hanrahan in failing to implement the will of voters.

"Only three of the eight sites have been acquired, and none of these are developed or equipped," he said. "In the meantime, land prices have risen tremendously."

Dugan said the county manager was largely responsible for dragging out the issue, and if he didn't get moving on it, he should be fired.

The challenger pooh-poohed Campbell's comments that playgrounds were on the way as nothing more than election pandering.

"It has been abundantly clear that if Mr. Campbell had been really interested in expediting the playground program, he would have been demanding action long prior to this election," Dugan said.

Third candidate's departure changes dynamics

With two challengers attempting to unseat him, Campbell had every reason to believe they would split the vote and guarantee his victory in days long before ranked-choice voting arrived in Arlington.

But in early September, everything changed: Howe dropped out of the race and endorsed Dugan.

Howe's decision was based on realpolitik considerations: "It is obviously better for us to unite and win, rather than for both of us to lose in a three-cornered race," he said.

In pulling out, Howe said he hoped an organization would be formed to support County Board candidates unaffiliated with political parties.

Howe would disappear from politics, but his dream achieved reality in the 1950s. Arlingtonians for a Better County, on the liberal side of the political spectrum, and the more conservative and less long-lasting Arlington Independent Movement, would serve as nonpartisan political organizations.

With the race now a one-on-one affair, the Campbell campaign attempted to tie Dugan to the Arlington County Republican Committee.

Arlington's GOP had not fielded a candidate but, in shades of John Vihstadt's 2014 campaign, opted to endorse Dugan's independent candidacy.

Democratic leaders used that to denounce Dugan as "a Republican in sheep's clothing." The challenger attempted to laugh off the accusation.

"The 'machine' which controls the Democratic Party in Arlington is carrying on a program of misrepresentation," he said in comments reported Oct. 4 by the Sun. "They know full well that I am an independent candidate and I am not the Republican Party candidate."

Facing off at the Organized Women Voters

In late September, Campbell and Dugan faced off in a forum sponsored by the Organized Women Voters of Arlington.

Campbell was critical of what he saw as Dugan twisting facts while on the campaign trail.

While praising Dugan's military service, Campbell — himself a World War I veteran — said "the fact that Mr. Dugan fought does not give him the right to campaign on reckless irresponsibilities and to make statements he knows to be untrue," the Sun reported.

Dugan stuck to his key issues, notably the need for nonpartisan leadership on the local governing body.

"Partisan elections deprive a community of many honest and capable citizens who are not in politics, and who will not try to get elected to public office where party nominations

are useful,” he said.

Election Day finally arrives

The Arlington Daily was an afternoon newspaper, and its Election Day (Nov. 5) edition noted the “exceedingly large” morning turnout among the Arlington electorate.

More than 4,600 had cast ballots by noon, coverage noted.

In the days leading up to the election, Campbell’s election manager, C. Harrison Mann, had tried to hammer home to voters that the challenger and his campaign manager, Harley Williams, were playing fast and loose with facts on issues ranging from zoning to playgrounds.

Dugan’s tactics “should be beneath the dignity of a candidate who is seeking as important a position as the County Board,” Mann was quoted as saying in the Nov. 1 Arlington Daily.

Dugan seemed to be ignoring the criticism. Four days before the election, his campaign held a countywide rally at Lyon Park Community Center, the Chronicle noted.



Arlington Daily front page on Election Day 1946 (via Library of Virginia)

Just one of multiple races

The lone County Board race on the Nov. 5, 1946, ballot was just one of a number for Arlington's electorate.

Not one but two U.S. Senate seats were up for grabs:

- Sen. Harry Byrd, the commonwealth's undisputed political leader, was seeking a new term in a field that included Republican, Socialist, Communist and Prohibitionist candidates and an independent
- Democrats had fielded A. Willis Robertson — father of future televangelist Pat Robertson — as their candidate for the Senate seat left vacant by the death of incumbent Carter Glass, facing off against a Republican and independent

Also on the ballot was the 8th District U.S. House of Representatives' seat held for more than a decade by Democrat Howard "Judge" Smith. He was being challenged by Republican Lawrence Michael.

Smith had unsuccessfully attempted to convince the Byrd machine to nominate him for Glass's Senate seat. Robertson got the nod instead, so Smith opted to seek re-election to his House seat.

Voters across Virginia also were being asked to weigh in on a referendum that would permit the state government to tax federal-government lands in the commonwealth.

That referendum came with a catch: Congress would need to agree to such taxation.

Democrats rattled at national level

President Harry Truman wasn't on the ballot in November 1946. But the growing unpopularity of the man who had succeeded Franklin Roosevelt in 1945 was certainly on voters' minds.

In its Nov. 6 edition, the Arlington Daily's banner headline blared "NEW DEAL DIES, GOP HOLDS CONGRESS." Its front page was a mix of national, state and local election results — few of them good news for Democrats, be they of the liberal or conservative wing of the party.

Republicans had won control of both houses of Congress for the first time in 14 years, and picked up a large number of governorships.

While Democrats were getting pummeled in some parts of the nation, both Byrd and Robertson won healthy majorities across Virginia, and each won all 11 Arlington precincts.

Smith's reelection to the House of Representatives suggested that the 8th District was moving, slightly, toward greater competitiveness. Republican Lawrence Michael won just under 40% of the district vote and came oh-so-close (49.4%) to winning a majority of Arlington votes.

Like the rest of the commonwealth, Arlington voters overwhelmingly supported the referendum giving Virginia authority to tax federal lands. Predictably, Congress never granted the necessary authorization; federal lands remain nontaxable to this day.

Despite the heated nature of campaign season, no violence was reported at the polls in Arlington, the Arlington Daily noted.

ARLINGTON ELECTION RESULTS															
	County Board		Senate					Senate		Congress		Referendum			
	Campbell (D)	Dugan (Ind.)	Byrd (D)	Parsons (R)	Burke (Com.)	Carville (Ind.)	Boorde (Prob.)	Robb (Soc.)	Robertson (D)	Woods (R)	Wilkes (Ind.)	Smith (D)	Michael (R)	For	Against
Arlington	780	1183	912	863	60	74	15	49	948	851	143	890	1061	1426	414
Ballston	793	1097	864	789	42	39	22	46	904	750	125	789	977	1343	342
Carne	482	516	557	376	27	16	8	21	518	408	71	522	479	811	226
Cherrydale	402	401	461	308	11	17	7	13	435	314	41	423	393	638	153
Clarendon #1	348	328	394	259	7	12	5	4	401	246	23	367	313	522	129
Clarendon #2	481	488	623	291	21	12	14	17	619	289	52	590	384	770	150
E. Falls Church	272	241	286	202	9	4	0	16	287	200	33	270	248	409	83
Glen Carlyn	81	164	119	104	8	3	6	8	116	98	27	115	127	144	59
Lyon Park	390	500	514	331	20	19	10	17	487	344	69	443	451	700	171
Rosslyn	366	437	454	292	29	25	9	13	454	287	57	412	402	578	191
Virginia Highlands	447	435	505	320	18	19	11	17	506	318	54	515	397	657	186
Total (11 Precincts)	4842	5790	5689	4135	252	240	107	221	5695	4165	697	5336	5232	8028	2104

Arlington election results, 1946 (Arlington Daily via Library of Virginia)

Dugan wins, sets priorities

Day-after coverage of the local race showed Dugan winning 5,790 votes to 4,749 for Campbell. The challenger won seven county voting precincts to four for Campbell, in what the Arlington Daily called “the greatest political upset in recent county history.”

In its election post-mortem, the Chronicle said the ousted incumbent was a victim of circumstance.

“The upset is believed to be a protest against the Democratic Party in the county, rather than against Campbell,” its front-page coverage noted.

Nearly 80 years later, Fogarty came to essentially the same conclusion.

“There was emphatic opposition to the Byrd machine,” he said at his Historical Society presentation.

Fogarty also concurred with the Arlington Daily’s view that it had been the biggest upset in County Board history, adding that it hadn’t been topped in the eight decades since.

“I don’t know all the County Board elections, but I think I’m on pretty good ground here,” he said.

In their post-election comments, Campbell and Dugan put the vitriol of campaign season behind them.

The challenger called Campbell “a thorough gentleman” and “the best member on the County Board.”

Campbell said he wasn’t sure whether he’d run for office again, but said “I expect to continue to take an active interest in civic affairs where best needed.”

Asked by an Arlington Daily reporter to lay out his goals when in office, Dugan spotlighted three: support for veterans, addressing the housing shortage and setting up “an accredited Negro high school” as part of a broader prioritization of school improvements.

W-L students weigh in

While adults (21 and older) were voting at polling places, students in civics classes at what then was Washington-Lee High School were holding their own mock elections for local offices on Nov. 5, 1946.

Northern Virginia Sun coverage doesn't quite make clear whether the students were selecting those they wanted to win, or those they thought were going to win, the vote in Arlington. But their selections came pretty close to the actual voting.

Students voted for Dugan over Campbell and for Byrd and Robertson for the U.S. Senate seats. All those tracked with final Arlington election results.

Civics students diverged in the 8th District U.S. House of Representatives' race, voting for Republican Michael over incumbent Democratic Smith.

At least in Arlington, Michael came very close, as the Republican won 49.4% of the county's vote. Across the 8th District in its entirety, however, he mustered only 37.9% of the vote, winning only Greene County among the 17 counties and cities that then comprised the 8th.

To fast forward: The conservative Rep. Smith would eventually become chair of the powerful House Rules Committee, serving until he was ousted by a left-leaning opponent, George Rawlings, in the 1966 Democratic primary.

Rawlings would be defeated in the 1966 general election by Republican William Scott.

Goodbye to becoming a city?

[Crandal Mackey](#) is known in Arlington history as the crusading commonwealth's attorney who, in 1903, cleaned up Rosslyn of its varied elements of vice, from gambling dens to houses of prostitution to a racetrack.

More than four decades later, long gone from public office, Mackey wielded a pen rather than his famous shotgun as he wrote editorials for the Chronicle newspaper.

In the paper's first editorial after the 1946 election results were in, Mackey and the Chronicle said Dugan's victory should put a stake through the heart of plans to make Arlington a city.

Campbell's "plan to incorporate the county should follow him in defeat," the editorial noted.

Welcome to the County Board

If Edmund Campbell had any lingering hostility toward Dugan once the campaign was concluded, he did not show it publicly. In fact, he invited the incoming Board member to sit with him on the dais during the body's two December meetings, so Dugan could get a feel for the rhythm of local governance.

At the last meeting of December, one of Campbell's four colleagues was absent, but the other three paid tribute to their departing colleague.

"I shall miss him," said Board member F. Freeland Chew in coverage reported by the Sun. "We have differed many times, but in most instances saw eye to eye."

Board member Basil DeLashmutt said Campbell's eight-year tenure would be remembered positively.

"I consider him one of the most capable among those who have ever been on the Board," he said.

DeLashmutt said Dugan was joining the Board with the community's "great expectations" behind him, and predicted he would "adequately fill" the seat.

Dugan officially assumed office, and began to draw his \$1,200 annual salary, on Jan. 1.

Building an independent majority

It took time, but Dugan's dream of a County Board with an independent majority began to take shape. In 1949, Robert Cox was elected to the Board, bringing the number of independents to two — still a minority of the five-member board.

Dugan's 1950 bid for re-election faced few headwinds. Winning 9,931 votes, he easily defeated Democrat Fred Bach (5,497) and independent Jacob Bechtel (1,049).

In 1951, two of the five seats were on the ballot. In a field of nine candidates, Republican Robert Peck (of [Bob Peck's Chevrolet](#) fame) finished first with 5,299 votes, followed by independent Alan Dean with 4,777.

Which meant that, when the 1952 County Board convened in January, independents held a majority and could start implementing some of their policies.

But not for long.

'I Did It Myself'

Arlington Official Dan Dugan Found Shot in Chest at Home

Arlington County Board member Daniel A. Dugan was rushed to Arlington Hospital late yesterday afternoon with a .22 caliber rifle bullet wound in his left breast.

"I did it myself," Dugan was quoted by police as telling a policeman.

His condition was described as "good" by hospital authorities.

County police said his wife, Mrs. Jeanne Dugan, told them the 34-year-old administrative assistant in the Labor Department came home from work about 5:30 p. m. and went directly to his upstairs bedroom. She said she was preparing dinner.

Almost at once, police quoted her as saying, she heard a shot. She said she ran upstairs and found Dugan conscious on the floor, a .22 rifle on the bed beside him. He was stripped to the waist.

On March 12, Dugan was charged by an Arlington grand jury for "malfeasance, misfeasance, and official neglect of duty." He faces trial April 23 on ouster proceedings recommended by the grand jury.

Dugan was taken to the hospital by the Clarendon ambulance and immediately underwent treatment in the emergency room.



The Washington Post

DANIEL A. DUGAN
Found Wounded in Bedroom

A bizarre interlude

Before getting to the events of 1952 that saw the three County Board independents kicked out of office, it's worth pausing at a somewhat bizarre occurrence the preceding year. In late March 1951, local newspapers reported that Dugan was in Arlington Hospital following a self-inflicted gunshot wound to the chest.

Just weeks before, Dugan had been charged by a grand jury with malfeasance, misfeasance and official neglect of duty, according to Washington Post coverage.

According to coverage at the time, Dugan was alleged to have appointed to a commission investigating criminal activity a man with "intimate associations" with slot-machine operators.

Dugan denied the charges, and was slated to have his day in court the following month. But the stress apparently got to him.

"A man can only stand so much," The Post reported he told a police officer at the hospital.

He would later tell the Sun that "I guess I just went off my rocker."

After a five-day trial in May that included testimony by nearly 40 witnesses, Judge John Ingram of Richmond ruled the commonwealth's attorney had not proved the case. Dugan was found not guilty.

"The capacity crowd broke into sharp applause, which the judge did not rebuke," Sun coverage reported.

"Thank God the truth has prevailed," Dugan's wife said in response to the verdict.

It was not, however, a complete vindication. Dugan's attorney, progressive state legislator Armistead Boothe, acknowledged his client was guilty of "indiscretions" in some of his associations with persons of questionable repute.

The indiscretions did not, however, rise to the level of criminality, Boothe successfully argued.

Noting the suicide attempt of the previous month, the Sun reported Dugan looked “worn and thin” during proceedings, and needed a cane to get around.

Virginia High Court Upholds Ouster of 3 From Arlington Board

By Matt McNeely
Post Reporter

The Virginia Supreme Court of Appeals yesterday upheld a Virginia law of 1787 prohibiting Federal employees from holding State or local office.

The unanimous opinion, handed down in Staunton by Justice Willis D. Miller, ousted three non-partisan members of the Arlington County Board. It also disqualifies about half of Arlington's present inapplying population from holding any county office.

In the 26-page opinion, the high court affirmed and amended the decision of Judge Walter F. McCarthy of Arlington Circuit Court. Judge McCarthy had held last May that the old statute barring Federal employees from jobs was constitutional and that a specific exemption, passed by the General Assembly on Arlington's behalf in 1928, was illegal.

The exemption was based on the density of the county's population, making it possible for Arlington alone to qualify. Federal employees had served on the Arlington County Board since that time.

Green Suit Upheld

Specifically, Judge McCarthy and the high court upheld a suit filed by John Locke Green, former county treasurer, for six Arlington residents who contested the right of Alan L. Dean to sit on the board because he is a Federal employee.

But the order covers Board Chairman Robert W. Cox and Daniel A. Dugan, who was a Federal employee when he was elected to a second term.

While the appellate court upheld Judge McCarthy on the two counts, it said he erred in not declaring Dean's office vacant, preventing him from acting as a board member and restraining the county treasurer from continuing to pay his salary.

The court amended Judge McCarthy's original decree to declare Dean's office vacant as of January 1, 1952, the first day of his tenure, and to order the county treasurer to cut off his salary as of yesterday.

The defendants—including Dean, County Treasurer Colin C. MacPherson, members of the board and Mrs. Ruby C. Simpson, board clerk—had appealed Judge McCarthy's decision on the grounds the 1787 law violated Virginia's constitution. But their attorneys argued that the specific exemption for Arlington was legal under the constitution if the general old law was constitutional.

Holding Explained

In giving its long-awaited opinion, the high court explained why the old law was passed.

The object, Justice Miller wrote, “was, and is, to safeguard and protect the State's independent sovereignty by requiring strict and undivided allegiance to the duties and obligations of the public office by its incumbent.”

“Its justification is the need for its enactment is traceable to and based on the principle that complete and undivided loyalty and fidelity are owed by a public officer to his trust and to the sovereign that created the office and made it available to the electors. Recognition of and adherence to that age-old truth are as important today as when legislation was first adopted.”

The opinion stated that “long continued sanction of this act by its repeated reenactment from time to time by the General Assembly, the positive application and enforcement of its mandate by this court, and the continued acquiescence and adherence to its restrictions by the departments of the State government, impel the belief and confirm our conclusion that it does not infringe on a citizen's constitutional rights.”

Law Is ‘General’

The high court found no merit in the defendants' assertion that the old law “is special and private legislation.” Rather, the court declared, the legislation is general in character and deals with a subject well within the field of general legislation.

It said the law applies alike to all officeholders, with “no inherent limitation or restriction therein which separates any persons, places or things of the same general class.”

Elsewhere in the opinion, the court declared, “It is to be kept in mind that the right to be elected to public office and the right of incumbency are not natural, absolute and inalienable rights inherent in all individuals. They are rather political privileges upon which may be imposed reasonable qualifications, conditions and restrictions in the interest of the public.”

The court then explained that the law imposes certain qualifications and conditions on a person who assumes to occupy and hold an office. The law specifies that no person shall be capable of holding any State or local office of honor, profit or trust if he holds “any office or post for profit, trust or emolument, civil or military, legislative, executive or judicial under the Government of the United States.”

If an office holder should enter Government service or accept any gain from it, the law states, he “shall lose facts vacate” the first office.

Similar Laws Cited

The court of opinion said other State constitutions and statutes frequently provide similar restrictions and Congress “has enacted legislation making this policy generally applicable to officers and employees of the Federal Government.”

Of the 1928 amendment, the Supreme Court had a strong and different opinion.

During that year, Arlington County Judge Hugh Reid was a

handing down its decision until the September session in Staunton.

Meanwhile, Attorney General pursued his campaign to unseat the nonpartisans. He filed a suit against Dean and Cox in United States District Court in Alexandria and got a temporary injunction to restrain them from voting on an Arlington rent control measure.

Judge Albert V. Bryan issued out the suit last Friday, dissolved the temporary injunction and ruled that a Federal court has no authority to remove the two men from their county jobs.

The ruling said the special exemption for certain counties “thus necessarily limits, amends, and partially repeals” the general old law.

The court opinion went on to say that provisions permitting Federal workers to hold office in sections with large populations “are unreasonable, unsecured and arbitrary classifications and exclusions. That character of legislation is forbidden and condemned by (the law). Its infirmity so patently appears upon its face that the unusual presumption of constitutionality of a legislative act does not protect it.”

The defendants' appeal of Judge McCarthy's decision was argued before the Supreme Court in Richmond June 10. However, the court delayed

1928 Law ‘Arbitrary’

“By arbitrary classification,” the Supreme Court said yesterday, “it undertakes to remove from the effect of (the law) a

... Arlington Board members ousted by court decision

Alvin Dean Robert Cox Daniel Dugan

Washington Post coverage of 1952 ouster of County Board members (via Arlington Public Library)

Tossed out of office

Unrelated to the events of 1951, Republican county treasurer John Locke Green filed suit in 1952, alleging that Dugan, Dean and Cox were holding office unlawfully.

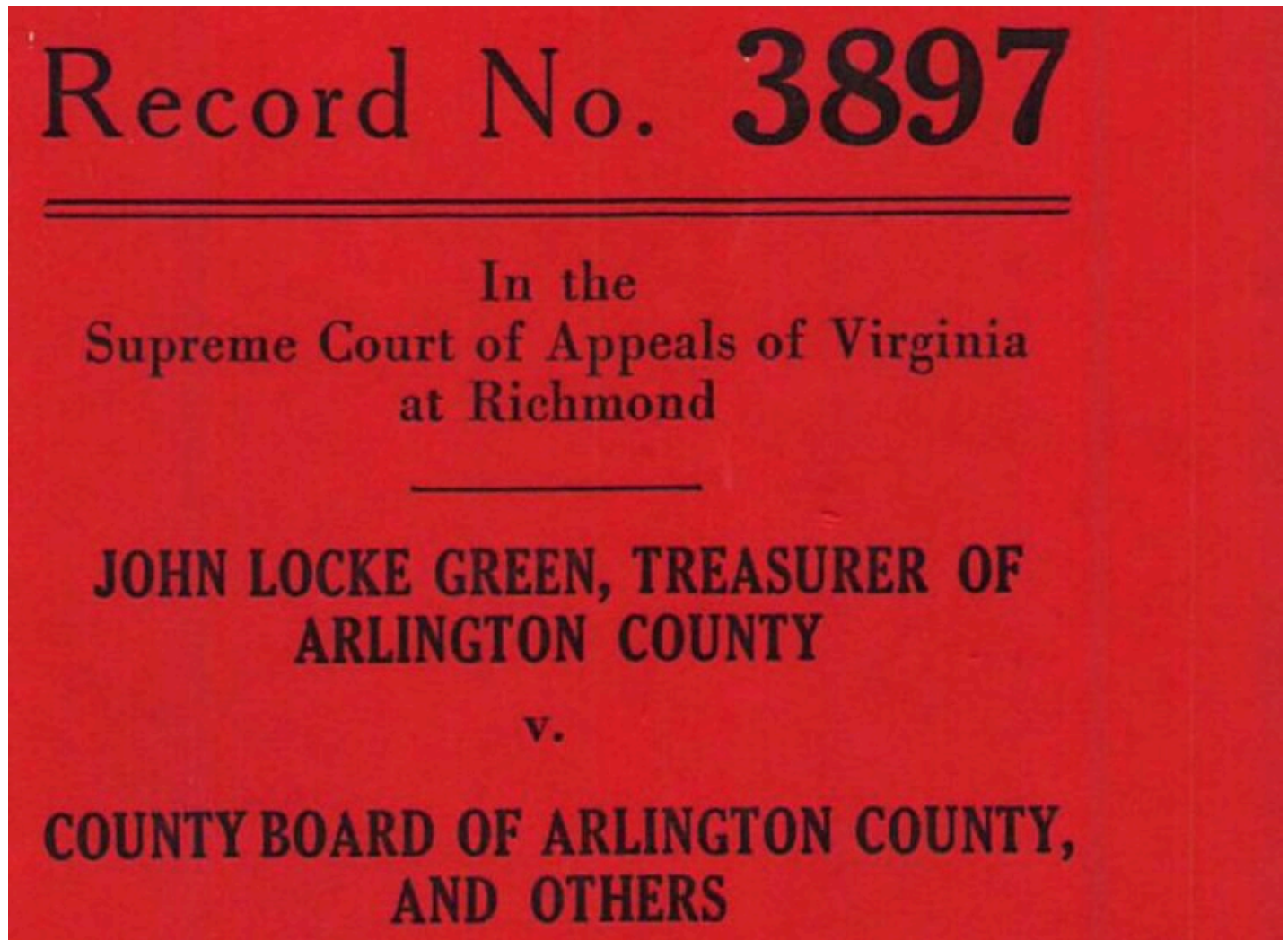
The basis for his suit was a law enacted in 1788 by the General Assembly, declaring that no federal employee could serve in any local or state elected office in the commonwealth.

Dugan, Dean, Cox and their supporters were banking on a 1928 law, passed by the General Assembly specifically for Arlington, providing an exemption from the prohibition on federal workers in local elected office.

Their arguments did not sway McCarthy, who in May 1952 ruled that the three were not eligible to hold office based on the 164-year-old law.

Nor did they sway the Virginia Supreme Court of Appeals, which in a [36-page ruling](#) issued in September 1952 said the 1788 law was valid, the 1928 one was not, and the three elected officials must give up their seats.

That included Dugan, even though he had lost his federal job with the U.S. Civil Service Commission as part of a series of reductions-in-force implemented by the Truman administration.



Ruling in lawsuit over legality of federal employees serving on the County Board (via Washington & Lee University)

At the time of the ruling, Dugan was operating an upholstery-cleaning business in Arlington, according to coverage in The Washington Post.

The ruling said that any reasonable restriction on holding elected office “does not infringe on a citizen’s constitutional rights.”

“The right to be elected to public office and the right of incumbency are not natural, absolute and inalienable rights inherent in all individuals,” the court ruled. “They are rather political privileges, upon which may be imposed reasonable qualifications, conditions and restrictions in the interest of the public.”

The ruling, in language perhaps a little arcane for the layman, also affirmed the primacy of the General Assembly and the role of the courts to pay deference to it:

“The passage of an act by the legislature is a solemn declaration and affirmance by that branch of government of its constitutional power to enact the legislation and its unconstitutionality must plainly appear before a court can declare it void. Every reasonable presumption must be indulged and accorded it in favor of its legality.”

If the three displaced County Board members and their legal team considered attempting to make a federal court case out of the matter, such an effort never seemed to have transpired.

Under state law of the time, the power to fill the three vacancies belonged to Judge McCarthy. His selections, announced in mid-September, further infuriated backers of the independents, according to Washington Post coverage.

McCarthy tapped two Democrats, Howard Massey and M. Rex Byrne, and a Democratic-leaning independent, John Tillema, to fill the seats.

Their tenures, however, would be brief. Each would serve less than two months, until the winners of special elections to fill their seats had been certified by the court.

What became of the other two elected officials whose political careers were cut short in 1952?

Dean served as an economist with the Federal Reserve Board. He died in 2011 at age 92.

Cox, who died in 1983 at age 67, retired as director of administration with the National Foundation on the Arts & Humanities.

Democratic Control Looms in Arlington



John Tillema

Howard Massey

M. Rex Byrne

... to serve as interim members of Arlington County Board

2 of 3 Successors To Independents Ousted by Ruling Will Be Democrats

By William H. Smith
Post Reporter

Two Democrats and an independent with Democratic leanings will serve as interim members of the Arlington County Board, pending a special election November 4 to replace three members ousted by a court ruling Wednesday.

Washington Post coverage of Democrats appointed to County Board in 1952 (via Arlington Public Library)

Three County Board races at once

After the final court ruling, Dugan, no longer a federal employee, said he planned to run for office in 1952. In the end, his name was not on the November 1952 ballot as Arlington voters cast ballots for all three positions:

- Alvin Kimel won Dean's seat, which ran to the end of 1955
- Leone Buchholz won Dugan's seat, running to the end of 1954
- Dr. Robert Detwiler won Cox's seat, running to the end of 1953

That same November 1952 election also included a referendum on incorporation as a city. The final tally: 3,450 Arlington voters in favor, 27,523 against.

In a rerun of 1946, Sen. Byrd won re-election, as did Rep. Smith.

A last political attempt by Campbell

Edmund Campbell's 1946 defeat was not the end of the political road for him.

In 1952, Democrats nominated Campbell as their candidate for the newly created 10th Congressional District, where he faced off against another Arlingtonian, Republican Joel Broyhill.

With the Truman administration still unpopular and Dwight Eisenhower running atop the Republican ticket for president, the conservative Broyhill was able to [eke out a victory](#) by just a few hundred votes.

He would serve in the post for two decades, only occasionally threatened ([as in 1964](#)) by a growing influx of a newer breed of liberal Democrats across the district.

Ultimately, Broyhill ended up a casualty of the Watergate scandal. Though he played no role in the malfeasance that forced Richard Nixon from office, the taint of Watergate on Republicans was enough to give Arlington County Board member Joseph Fisher victory in 1974.

Fisher would represent the 10th District until being ousted by Republican Frank Wolf in 1980. During Wolf's three-decade tenure, Arlington was moved out of the 10th District and back into the 8th.

Picking up the pieces

With their political aspirations apparently in the rear-view mirror, one-time opponents Dugan and Campbell would collaborate in the mid-1950s to create Arlingtonians for a Better County, known as ABC, which for four decades was a potent force in local governance.

The organization endorsed candidates who did not wish to run under a partisan label. Among them was Ellen Bozman, who for the first five of her six County Board victories — 1973, 1977, 1981, 1985 and 1989 — was officially a candidate of ABC, albeit with tacit Democratic support.

In 1958, Campbell led a new task force on potentially making Arlington a city. As with previous efforts, “it didn’t go anywhere,” Fogarty said in his remarks.

After leaving the County Board, Dugan found work as a construction superintendent, including for the Metro system. He also wrote several books, as well as poetry. Campbell would continue the practice of law and segue into the role of Virginia elder statesman.

Flash forward to 2026

One can, if willing to do the research, compile a direct line of office-holders for each of the five County Board seats from the time of their creation nearly a century ago to the present day.

For the seat held by Campbell and then Dugan, after Buchholz came Leo Urbanske (elected in 1958), Ned Thomas (1966), Joseph Wholey (1970), Stephen Detwiler (1978), Mary Margaret Whipple (1982), Chris Zimmerman (1996), John Vihstadt (2014) and Matt de Ferranti (2018).

Like the other four seats on the five-member body, that list of occupants includes a mix of those who remain household names — at least to those who follow local politics — and those whose tenures in office have become more obscure as time marched on.

And if the name Stephen Detwiler sticks out, it is because he was the son of Dr. Robert Detwiler, mentioned earlier as one of those elected in 1952.

De Ferranti is currently seeking to hold onto the seat, having announced in early January plans to run for re-election. He is being challenged in the Democratic primary by James DeVita, who has previously run twice for County Board and once for State Senate.

The general-election field has yet to firm up, but the winner of the Nov. 3 election is likely to occupy the Campbell-Dugan seat into the 2030s.

Thanks to the Library of Virginia, Charlie Clark Center for Local History, Arlington Historical Society and the Arlington library system assisting with research.

About the Author



Scott McCaffrey

A Northern Virginia native, Scott McCaffrey has four decades of reporting, editing and newsroom experience in the local area plus Florida, South Carolina and the eastern panhandle of West Virginia. He spent 26 years as editor of the Sun Gazette newspaper chain. For Local News Now, he covers government and civic issues in Arlington, Fairfax County and Falls Church.

#County Board

#history

#politics



Featured Event